

1995 ▶ 2000

1997

El Niño phenomenon

El Niño is a warming of the ocean surface that periodically occurs in the tropical regions of the Pacific Ocean. It changes how winds move and, with it, rainfall patterns over much of the planet. In 1997–1998, the strongest El Niño on record resulted in an increase in extreme weather, including severe droughts in Southeast Asia and record rainfalls and flooding in South America.



Heavy flooding, caused by El Niño in 1997–1998, destroyed most of the houses in Chato Grande, Peru.

1995

Galileo orbits Jupiter

NASA's Galileo became the first space probe to orbit Jupiter. The probe discovered ammonia clouds in Jupiter's atmosphere, measured volcanic activity on Jupiter's moon, Io, and found evidence of saltwater under the surface of three other moons of Jupiter: Callisto, Ganymede, and Europa.

1996

First successful cloning of a mammal

Scientists at the Roslin Institute in Edinburgh, Scotland, created the first healthy mammal by cloning (making an identical copy of) a single cell from an adult sheep. Dolly the sheep was born in July 1996. Later she would give birth to three healthy litters of lambs.



1995

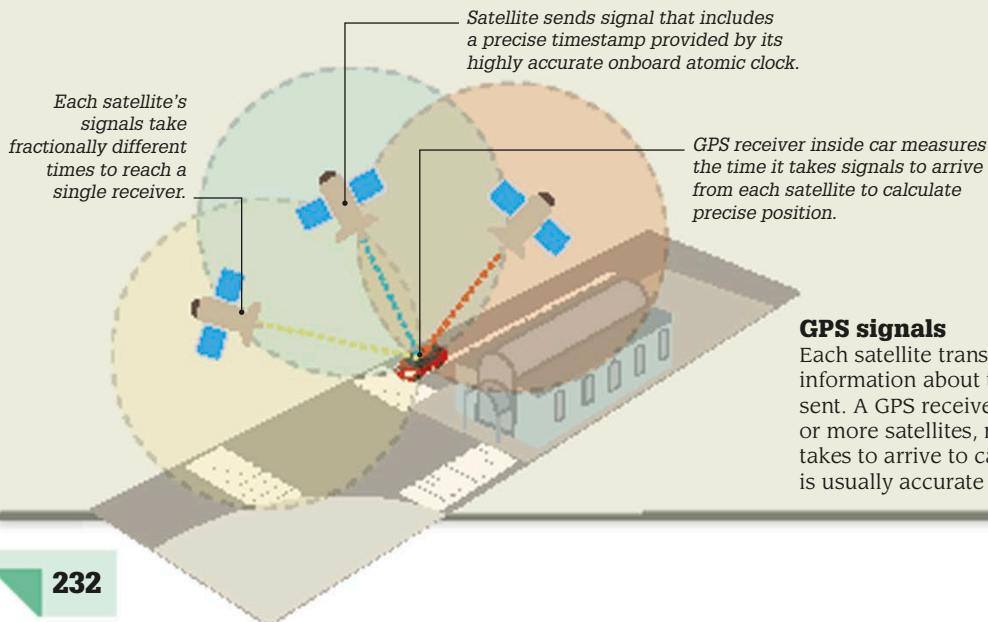
1995 GLOBAL POSITIONING SYSTEM (GPS)

The Global Positioning System (GPS) started as a network of 24 satellites (now expanded to 31) that orbit Earth twice a day at an altitude of 12,552 miles (20,200 km). Groups of four satellites travel on the same orbital plane to provide comprehensive navigation coverage.



Satellite navigation

An in-car "sat nav" combines a GPS receiver with digital road maps and software to give a constantly updated location and to provide directions to destinations. Since 2000, car drivers and other civilian users have had access to a higher-accuracy GPS signal previously available only to the military.



GPS signals

Each satellite transmits radio signals encoded with information about the precise time the signal was sent. A GPS receiver gathers in the signals from three or more satellites, measuring the time each signal takes to arrive to calculate its precise location. This is usually accurate to within a handful of meters.